

Try four types of tasks:

- **Screenshot troubleshooting:** "Describe the error shown in this screenshot and suggest three likely causes."
- **Chart reading:** "Explain what this chart shows. Separate visible facts from your interpretation."
- **Document inspection:** "List the headings, dates and amounts visible on this page."
- **Image description:** "Describe the objects and spatial relationships in this photograph without guessing identities."

That final phrase is important. Vision models can confidently infer things that are not actually visible.

Step-by-step: test a VLM honestly

Use an image whose contents you already understand.

Ask the model first for a literal description. Then ask five factual questions whose answers you can independently verify. Include one question about something that is not visible.

A trustworthy response should acknowledge the missing information rather than inventing it.

Do the same with a chart containing known numbers. Vision performance should be evaluated not by how fluent the description sounds but by whether it reads labels, values and relationships correctly.

5. Test it in the languages you actually use

For an Indian reader, English-only evaluation is not enough. A model that writes excellent English may become awkward when the conversation moves to Hindi, Tamil, Marathi, Bengali or everyday code-mixed speech.

Large global models increasingly advertise broad multilingual support. Gemma 4 claims support for more than 140 languages. But "supported" still does not tell you whether a model handles colloquial expressions, transliterated Hindi or your preferred regional language naturally.

India also has specialist open resources. AI4Bharat's IndicTrans2 covers all 22 scheduled Indian languages and releases its translation models, training data, evaluation benchmarks and inference scripts; its model checkpoints use the MIT licence. Its BPCC training resource contains roughly 230 million parallel text pairs.

Do not turn this into another leaderboard. Build your own language test.

Use five prompts:

1. Ask a general question in English.
2. Ask the same question in your Indian language.
3. Write that language in Latin transliteration.
4. Mix English and the Indian language naturally.
5. Ask for a translation of colloquial speech rather than textbook prose.

Record whether the model preserves meaning, handles names correctly, invents translations or unexpectedly switches languages.

If translation is your main job, a specialist model such as IndicTrans2 may make more sense than forcing a general chatbot to perform every conversion.



KNOW WHEN THE CLOUD STILL WINS

Local AI is a choice, not a religion. Use cloud AI when the job needs live web information, a frontier model that your hardware cannot approach, very large-scale processing or a service-specific capability you do not have locally. Cloud systems also remove the need to manage model files, memory and updates yourself.

Local AI makes more sense when privacy, offline access, repeatability or zero marginal prompt cost matters more than having the strongest possible model. A useful habit is to classify tasks before starting: LOCAL for private documents and routine transformations, CLOUD for live research and maximum capability, and EITHER for ordinary brainstorming. The best personal AI setup can contain both. Running your own model should expand your choices, not force every problem onto your laptop.